

Overview of Online Travel Planning

Travel planning shifted from physical agencies to online platforms following the rise of online travel agencies (OTAs) in 1996, beginning with the individual booking platform Booking.com [1]. OTAs aggregate flights, hotels and experiences in one place, use algorithms to personalise recommendations and allow easy comparison of options.

Early online marketing offered customers price transparency through easy comparison across currencies and channels [2]. However, recent research [3] shows customers now face hidden fees, manipulated reviews and fraudulent listings, making trustworthiness and price transparency problems platforms must be solved.

Despite these issues, the global online travel market is projected to grow from US\$540 billion in 2024 to nearly US\$1.95 trillion in 2033 driven by AI, peer reviews, digital marketing, heightened reach, improved customer market position and ease of engagement [4][5][1].

Types of Travel Products and Agencies

Popular OTAs include Expedia, Travelocity, Tripadvisor, and Booking.com. However, package-based platforms differ from individual booking platforms: package-based platforms aggregate multiple travel components using supplier relationships to obtain bulk rates, offering customised itineraries and support for complex trips including group discounts and visa logistics assistance [6]. Individual booking platforms allow users to search, compare, and book single components, focusing on real-time price transparency, user reviews, and algorithm-driven filters. Although users receive less support and must handle their own coordination and disruptions with individual booking platforms, they tend to secure the best individual rates [8].

Packages consist of curated convenience and bundled value for complex and luxury travel [9]. Niche agencies cater to specific travel segments, demographics, or activities, providing curation that generalist platforms may miss [8]. Examples include Thermal (surfing), Winerist (wine tours), and Kidpass (kid-friendly activities) [8].

How Content is Rated and Categorised

Platform observation of the online travel agency, expedia.com [20] shows that content makes use of price ranges and the ability to sort and filter by price, destination tags and activity categories. Packages and options can be categorised by destination such as cities, countries or regions which, according to research [11], broadens the global traveller pool. Other categories include activity specialisation, including platforms such as BringFido which exclusively focuses on pet-friendly accommodations [11]. These categories help users find relevant experiences.

In addition to content organisation, ratings aid users in finding relevant experiences. Ratings have the objective of providing an assessment of quality and experience, however, reviews differ from ratings. Often, ratings do not match the customers' view of quality as star ratings reflect relevant features, whilst review scores tend to reflect that and more [10]. Verified ratings and reviews ensure transparency due to potential falsified reviews and ratings, ensuring that they come from another user and are not spam or from the company, making this an effective tactic to further increase transparency [3]. Other trust mechanisms include agency verification, review moderation and others necessary to avoid ambiguous policies, fraudulent listings and low base prices which exclude taxes and fees causing users to waste their time browsing packages they cannot truly afford. [3]

Additional Features

Platforms can handle group bookings through the use of dedicated online portals [12], shared booking links allowing travellers to book under a group whilst retaining their own tracking [13] and receiving discounts from airlines and dynamic pricing for block bookings ensuring profitability [14]. Further, for larger groups or groups with specific requirements, dedicated support teams can be used for any manual updates [15]. Hereafter, logistical systems make use of views to consolidate data and create reports to navigate logistics [13].

Online travel agencies aggregate data across agencies by use of web scraping, global distribution systems and API integrations to aggregate real-time pricing data from multiple sources and across competitor platforms [16]. Meta search engines such as skyscanner or kayak can consolidate rates from various sources, further aiding online travel agencies analyse pricing and promotions [17],[18]. Hereafter, the data is structured and analysed to present a view of options in one interface [19]. There are other price intelligence systems AI-driven algorithms and machine learning to process the aggregated data and enabling dynamic pricing [16].

Features which increase the popularity of online travel agency websites include personalisation through advanced algorithms [3], AI integration for streamlined experiences, dynamic pricing, quicker customer service through chatbots and mobile-based engagement to increase accessibility to the platforms [5]. It has been further studied [5] that peer reviews and online content encourage people to gain unique experiences through online travel agencies, particularly amongst gen z and millennials.

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